Foreword

I had not been playing for Western Province for long when a 16-year-old schoolboy called Herschelle Gibbs was selected to play against Northern Transvaal. I think he scored 37 runs on the day, but watching his style and flare for the game was enough to convince anyone that this youngster was going to be around for a long time.

And so, here I am, 20 years later, having been asked to write the foreword to the autobiography of Herschelle Gibbs – an honour indeed! Naturally, I jumped at the opportunity, feeling that it is important that people know the views and opinions of the person who spent many hours and days just 22 yards from him on the cricket pitch, as we battled it out against the best opposition in the world.

It was here, in the middle and under pressure, that I got to see Herschelle Gibbs at his purest and best. There were times when I saw the fear in his eyes, when I saw him vulnerable and unsure who he was and whether he belonged in this arena. But, more often than not, I saw the determination and confidence of an entertainer who had a deep desire to display his talents and skills in their truest form and show the cricketing world what he was made of.

In the early days, when Herschelle's confidence was soaring (and the game had yet to dish out a few harsh lessons, as it does to us all), his stroke-making was audacious! His trademark backfoot drive, which regularly soared over the cover boundary, is such a difficult shot that I have yet to see the batsmen of the new era even consider it. Such was Hersch's skill that I would often watch him select an area to hit the ball with little regard of the delivery's line or length. With Herschelle at the crease, it was cricket entertainment at its purest, and he relished and flourished in the adulation that came with it.